

NEW PATHWAYS TO THE LORD Pilgrims walk the newly built heritage corridor at the Jagannath Temple in Puri

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IN THIS SEASON OF TEMPLE AND TEMPLE TOWN makeovers, the Jagannath Temple in Puri, Odisha, stole a march over the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. Or perhaps that was exactly the reason why the Naveen Patnaik government chose to unveil its ambitious temple project—a Rs 800 crore heritage corridor around the 12th century shrine—on January 17, five days ahead of the grand event in Ayodhya on January 22. The early inauguration managed to draw the shrine some attention it would never have been able to attract in the forever afterglow of Ayodhya. And so it was that the Shree Mandira Parikrama Prakalpa—one component of a Rs 4,200 crore project aimed to transform Puri, one of the holiest of Hindu pilgrimage centres, into a world-class heritage city—was opened to the public.

PURI

"This is not the Puri we knew. What a welcome change our favourite pilgrimage site has undergone!" exults Manoj Thakur, a 52-year-old farmer who led a 50-strong contingent from Bhilai in Chhattisgarh on a week-long pilgrimage across the eastern states. He never expected to walk through air-conditioned, shaded pathways towards the temple. "The best part is now we can do the ritualistic *parikrama* (circumambulation). Jai Jagannath!" shouts his friend Panchu Ram, 50. It is precisely the enhancement of the pilgrim experience that the Augmentation of Basic Amenities and Development of Heritage and Architecture (ABADHA) initiative focuses on.

Puri is one of the four sacred sites or dhams of Hinduism, Badrinath, Dwarka and Rameswaram being the other three. Located in the four corners of the country,

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they are focal points of worship for a large proportion of practicing Hindus. While the ritual circumambulation was possible in the other three shrines, congestion and encroachment had left only a highly congested 10-15-metre wide pedestrian path around the temple in Puri. The new 75-metre-wide corridor surrounding the Jagannath Temple complex has now decongested the temple's external periphery after almost three years of rigorous work while providing pilgrims a visual connect with the temple. The mega project, the brainchild of the chief minister, was part of the state's flagship 5T (teamwork, transparency, technology and time leading to transformation) initiative. It was spearheaded by V.K. Pandian, 5T chairman and the CM's former secretary, who visited the city every Saturday to supervise work.

While the revival of the *parikrama* path is central to the project, government sources claim that the congestion also posed a threat to the security and sanctity of the temple. Pilgrims can now enjoy an unobstructed view of the temple from all sides, including the Badadanda (Grand Road) on the northeastern corner. This is the road the chariots of the deities—Jagannath, his brother Balabhadra and sister Subhadra—take during the annual seven-day Rath Yatra, when over a million devotees descend on the temple town. (On other days, Puri attracts 50,000-75,000 devotees a day, going up to 100,000 on weekends.) In